

A not so stellar 2013



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"For a year that promised so much, one that showered us with glittering gadgets and stellar services, some tech milestones just failed to rise to the occasion."

Another year comes to an end, and here at Digit we always marvel at the speed at which the annual clock ticks over – we often refer to stories done several months ago as something we did “very recently,” and stand convinced that within the confines of our office lies a time distortion field that bows to no one. Among the haze and blur of a barrage of products and services witnessed this year, there are some that have stuck in my memory better than others. For better or worse. For a year that promised so much, one that showered us with glittering gadgets and stellar services, the following tech milestones just failed to rise to the occasion.

Let me begin with the Google Chromecast, a wireless screen sharing HDMI dongle for your TV. At US\$ 35 it's not something you think twice before buying, but after buying it, I realised there isn't much to do with it – right now. Google restricts app support to a choice few on handheld devices and the Chrome browser on PCs, instead of making Chromecast an unrestricted portal to access any media – video, photos, documents, etc – from any device on to your HDTV. While the Chromecast has a lot of potential and is undoubtedly cheap, it's too restrictive in its current state and falls short of expectations.

The Blackberry Z10 is another disappointment of 2013 for me. Already late in the smartphone game, for RIM, as a company, the Z10 (based on BB10) was a landmark device prepped to take on the Androids and iPhones of the world. While it came packed with decent hardware, not a single dominating feature was to be found, something that would give the Z10 an obvious edge over the other flagships. Also, in the quest for unique appeal, BB10's gesture-based UI lacked any familiarity to basic navigation, and was just too alien for my taste. Despite its expensive price tag, the phone failed in its basic quest to attract customers from competing platforms.

Next on my list of tech disappointments is Windows 8(1) RT. It's Windows for ARM devices, but it looks exactly the same as a full-fledged Windows 8 on an x86 system – but it's a curtailed version of the Windows 8, obviously. Too confusing, right? I think so, too. And even now, over a year after its launch, there are still way too few apps to show. With companies like

ASUS, NVIDIA and Samsung publicly voicing their disappointment with Windows RT, looks like it will only be relegated to Microsoft devices like the Surface, Surface 2, and now the Nokia Lumia 2520. I'm all for a strong third platform to go against the Android iOS hegemony, however, Windows RT doesn't seem geared for battle in its current state. Horses for courses is good, but Windows RT right now is more of a show pony and no stallion.

And what saddens me deeply is the lost opportunity on the console front, that Xbox One and PS4 are already here, and the challengers didn't quite manage to get a foothold into the market. I'm talking about microconsoles like the OUYA (the crowd-funded \$99 gaming console), NVIDIA Shield, Gamestick, Gamepop, etc. Almost all of these low-cost game consoles are based on Android and tap into Google's Play Store for gaming apps, some of them have proprietary app stores to download games from. There was a brief window of opportunity this year for these devices to score some customers, ones who weren't looking to buy an Xbox 360 or PS3 – if they would've seen a great new console with a promising platform, they would've thrown money at it. But it wasn't to be. Neither are developers seeing any great value in developing for these devices, and more's the pity. All hopes rest on the upcoming Steam Machines to take on the might of Xbox and Playstation in the near future.

On a happier note, while Diwali has come and gone, I still haven't managed to buy an expensive HDTV for myself. Not for lack of HD content – contrary to the apprehensions voiced in my column in January 2013. I've realized that Diwali is probably the wrong time to buy high-end gadgets. Same with Christmas. I'm still waiting for a great deal – I'm stingy, sue me. About time we had an Indian version of Black Friday, don't you think?

While this year had its ups and downs, let's all hope and wish for an awesome 2014, one that makes us forget 2013 sooner than ever. Until next year, then. 